Check for updates

Main Article

etui.

Transfer
2023, Vol. 29(3) 323–338
© The Author(s) 2023
Article reuse guidelines:
sagepub.com/journals-permissions
DOI: 10.1177/10242589231177353
journals.sagepub.com/home/trs
Sage

Informal employment on domestic care platforms: a study on the individualisation of risk and unpaid labour in mature market contexts

Valeria Pulignano
Centre for Sociological Research (CeSo), Katholieke Universiteit Leuven, Belgium

Claudia Marà
Centre for Sociological Research (CeSo), Katholieke Universiteit Leuven, Belgium

Milena Franke
Centre for Sociological Research (CeSo), Katholieke Universiteit Leuven, Belgium

Karol Muszynski
Centre for Sociological Research (CeSo), Katholieke Universiteit Leuven, Belgium

Summary
This article explains how digitally mediated provision of domestic care services perpetuates the invisibility and informality of such work through individualising risk, which we operationalise by one of its dimensions, that of unpaid labour. We understand unpaid labour as the cost of the risk borne individually by workers at the intersection of the social (inter-personal) and economic (monetary) spheres. Drawing on the experiences of domestic care workers providing their services through platforms, the study shows how platforms have made their way into the labour markets and welfare structures of two mature economies, Belgium and France. Via their (digital) rules, they pursue 'regulatory compliance' and 'disruption' as distinct strategies for establishing platform dominance, albeit with country-based differences. Platform-mediated employment outcomes remain generally unrecognised, undocumented and informal, with unpaid labour characterising the cost of the individualisation of risk.

Résumé
Cet article explique comment la prestation des services de soins domestiques par le biais de la médiation numérique perpétue le caractère invisible et informel de ce type de travail en

Corresponding author:
Valeria Pulignano, Centre for Sociological Research (CeSO), KU Leuven, Parkstraat 45 - box 3601, Leuven, 3000, Belgium.
Email: valeria.pulignano@kuleuven.be

individualisant le risque : nous analyserons ce phénomène à partir d'une de ses dimensions, le travail non rémunéré. Nous entendons par travail non rémunéré le coût du risque supporté individuellement par les travailleurs à l'intersection des sphères sociale (interpersonnelle) et économique (monétaire). En se basant sur l'expérience des travailleurs domestiques qui offrent leurs services par l'intermédiaire de plateformes, l'étude décrit comment les plateformes ont réussi à se faire une place sur les marchés du travail et dans les structures sociales de deux économies matures, la Belgique et la France. Par l'intermédiaire de leurs règles (numériques), elles appliquent des stratégies distinctes de "conformité réglementaire" et de "perturbation" pour se créer une position dominante, même si des différences apparaissent d'un pays à l'autre. Les conditions des emplois créés par les plateformes restent généralement méconnues, non documentées et informelles, le travail non rémunéré caractérisant le coût de l'individualisation des risques.

Zusammenfassung

Der vorliegende Artikel erklärt, wie die digitale Vermittlung häuslicher Pflegedienstleistungen die Unsichtbarkeit und Informalität dieser Arbeit durch eine Individualisierung der Risiken verstetigt. Diese Risiken operationalisieren wir durch die damit verbundene Dimension der unbezahlten Arbeit. Wir verstehen unbezahlte Arbeit als Kosten für das individuell von den Pflegenden getragene Risiko an der Schnittstelle zwischen sozialer (interpersoneller) und ökonomischer (monetärer) Dimension. Auf Basis der Erfahrungen von Beschäftigten in der häuslichen Pflege, die ihre Dienste über Plattformen anbieten, zeigt die Studie, wie diese Plattformen ihren Weg in die Arbeitsmärkte und Wohlfahrtsstrukturen der beiden hoch entwickelten Volkswirtschaften Belgien und Frankreich gefunden haben. Über ihre (digitalen) Regeln verfolgen die Plattformen „Regelkonformität“ und „Disruption“ als zwei verschiedene Strategien zum Erreichen einer dominanten Position auf dem Arbeitsmarkt, die von Land zu Land jedoch unterschiedlich gestaltet werden. Die über Plattformen vermittelte Arbeit wird im Allgemeinen nach wie vor nicht anerkannt, ist nicht dokumentiert und informell. Unbezahlte Arbeit ist ein typisches Beispiel für die Kosten, die die Individualisierung von Risiken mit sich bringt.

Keywords

Domestic care work, labour platforms, informal work, unpaid labour, individualisation of risk, working conditions

Introduction

This article focuses on unpaid labour as a distinct but underexplored dimension of the ‘individualised risk’ associated with domestic care workers providing their services through domestic care platforms (hereinafter just ‘platforms’) in mature European market contexts in France and Belgium. Whereas several studies have pointed to unpaid labour being an important aspect of degrading platform working conditions (e.g. Berg et al., 2018; Pulignano and Marà, 2021; Rani et al., 2021), there is to date no systematic account of the processes driving unpaid labour on domestic care platforms and the implications for workers.

This article defines unpaid labour as a risk-related cost for domestic care workers, reflecting the economic (related to the material nature of the interaction) and social (related to its inter-personal nature) effort spent on performing tasks necessary to access and maintain paid employment through the platform (D’Cruz and Noronha, 2016). Importantly, this cost arises primarily in work

performed within the regulated domestic care sectors – in our case in France and Belgium – with platforms steering the transition of the employment relationship from formal to informal. We use the ILO definition of informal employment as casual work arrangements which are unreported, characterised by no fixed salary, and lacking social rights and protection (International Labour Organization [ILO], 2020). We contend that unpaid labour is performed as a result of the platform-driven informalisation of work arrangements, as witnessed in two mature labour market contexts featuring formalised domestic care service sectors (i.e., France and Belgium).

Macdonald (2021) employs the concept of 'individualised risk' to describe different types of risks common to domestic care workers' accounts of their experiences. These individualised risks play out at the micro-level and are influenced by a combination of structural factors, namely consumer choices, control, and market-driven prices, as well as market operations and practices arising from significant institutional, socio-economic and technological transformations. This article extends the concept of 'individualised risk' to describe a specific yet common form of risk (i.e., unpaid labour) mirrored in the day-to-day experiences of domestic care workers. Such work includes cleaning, babysitting, pet-sitting, private tutoring and personal assistance to the elderly (Friederici et al., 2022; Strüver and Bauriedl, 2022; Ticona and Mateescu, 2018). This risk consists of ('sunk') costs borne individually by the workers and which are necessary to complete tasks and to access and maintain paid employment through the platform. We illustrate how platform-mediated domestic care entails informal work arrangements dictated by a platform's algorithms to match clients with workers outside the formal framework of employment and social protection within two market economies, Belgium and France, with longstanding and encompassing policies formalising domestic care services.

As we will show, algorithmic management can induce unpaid labour through reputation mechanisms: i.e., the risk of a cost resulting from negative client feedback and inducing workers to put up with a client's additional requests. Moreover, while the inter-personal and servile dimension of domestic care work accounts for the unpaid nature of this work in non-digital settings as well, platform technologies exacerbate the unpaid dimension due to the cost of the risk incurred by workers. Respondents reported unpaid labour (i.e., not receiving any monetary compensation) stemming from scams and harassment caused by platform algorithms steering the matching without monitoring the modalities of the matching itself. For instance, workers are often left alone to figure out the safety of a prospective gig, leading to them taking cautionary measures against the potential dangers with which they are confronted (e.g. by notifying family members). Much of this risk is due to the opaque digital environment and low degree of moderation by the platform.

Such unpaid labour in platform-mediated domestic care work occurs at the intersection of social (inter-personal) and economic (financial) service interactions through platforms that operate in accordance with the 'corporate logic' of control (Frenken et al., 2020), with no attempt made to shelter workers from the risk stemming from the use of the platform's technology (Franke and Pulignano, 2021; Pulignano and Franke, 2022). As such, this unpaid labour is distinct from other forms of unpaid labour found within platform work such as idle waiting time in food delivery or ride-hailing work, work extensification in online freelancing, etc. (e.g. Berg et al., 2018; Pulignano and Marà, 2021; Pulignano et al., 2022; Rani et al., 2021).

We start by discussing two strands of theory and research of key importance for the analysis of domestic care platform services: – the unpaid care labour strand and the individualised risk strand – relating them to research on domestic care platforms to examine the specific features and identify the challenges faced by domestic care workers working on platforms. We go on to describe the research design and methodology, present the regulatory contexts in France and Belgium and explain how selected platforms operate. We then present the findings, discuss and conclude, with a focus on the theoretical and policy implications of our study.

Domestic care work, individualised risk and digital platforms

Literature on domestic care (hereinafter just 'care') understands such work as encompassing all social relations around the provision of care and considered contextual of distinct social market and non-market structures (Lawson, 2007). As Sevenhuijsen (2003: 183) argues: 'Care is part of the practices of active citizenship which is based on notions of relationality and interdependence'. Care is embedded in inter-personal social relations and can be performed in informal and formal contexts, i.e., in households, communities, organisations and the labour market (Hardill and Baines, 2011).

This broader understanding of domestic care work encompassing the formal and informal dimensions of the exchange or inter-personal relations (Fine, 2004) reveals the complexities and contradictions of such work. Classics have related the complexities of the social relations in care to its emotional aspects, reinforcing gendered undervaluation of unpaid domestic care work. Hochschild's (1983) thesis of 'emotional labour', taking the shape of female workers feeling and expressing emotions while providing inter-personal care services, shows how much of care work is usually hidden, devalued and consequently unpaid. Thus, the unpaid nature of domestic care work is underpinned by the artificial separation of work and the worker, which obscures the relational (or inter-personal) character of caregiving (Daniels, 1987). The key significance of the inter-personal character of care work has been widely discussed in the context of low-wage sectors or low-end service work expansion and might also include the necessity to 'figure out' clients' expectations and how work should be organised (Ehrenreich, 2010). Though care workers experience the inter-personal aspect of domestic care services as a source of great satisfaction (Anderson, 2007), employment conditions in care work are deteriorating (Meagher et al., 2016). Market-oriented public policies have contributed to socially and politically obscure the value of care work by viewing 'care users' as consumers and 'care' as a commodity bought and sold in the market (Brennan et al., 2012). These same policies have fostered the growth of platforms for the intermediation of care services provided in domestic environments (Frenken et al., 2020). In other words, the withdrawal of the state from the provision of care services in favour of outsourcing, privatisation and market competition has fostered a series of structural changes that eventually led to these services being mediated by platforms. These in turn have transformed 'the location of, and the parties to, work and care relations' (Macdonald, 2021: 139). Studies report that mega platforms (such as care.com, Uber and Airbnb) were founded in the immediate aftermath of the global financial crash (Sadowski, 2020) to offer a wide range of innovative services. Among them, domestic care services have acquired particular importance. Their growth was fuelled by the COVID-19 pandemic, as they took some pressure off people with care and household responsibilities who were struggling to juggle between work and domestic tasks during the disruptive lockdowns (Strüver and Bauriedl, 2022).

Building on Christensen and Manthorpe's (2016) concept of 'personalised risk', Macdonald (2021: 138–139) coined the notion of 'individualised risk' to examine how the governance through market ideas in social care has shaped employment in such a way as to create risks for workers. The author identifies several broad and intersecting categories of individualised risks, including the risk of isolating and individualising workers; the risk of fragmenting work, working time and work life; and the risk of gendered undervaluation. Risk in each of these categories is influenced by a combination of structural changes, including the market determination of pay and working conditions, market-driven operations and practices as well as consumers' choices and control. The idea behind the concept of individualised risk is that domestic care work is left open to being characterised as informal help where unpaid labour is likely to be more common because of the changes affecting the traditional protection of care work under the umbrella of employment protection (Ticona, 2022).

Studies in liberal market economies have illustrated that platforms may contribute to formalising employment relationships by fostering 'visibility' among workers traditionally conceived as 'invisible' (Mateescu and Ticona, 2022; Ticona and Mateescu, 2018). Scholarly work in the emerging and informal economies of the Global South has supported this claim by illustrating how platforms steer transitions from informality to formality as they require formal service provision, while many workers in this economy often value informality (Weber et al., 2021). Yet while platforms may enhance formality within contexts of regulatory and legal ambiguity, in more formalised labour markets platform-mediated domestic care work still tends to be informal, not readily identifiable and overt, and not recognised as work. For example, platforms have had a negative impact on the professionalisation of care in Australia, as professional care workers often end up performing platform-mediated work that remains informal and therefore not officially recognised within the scope of professional interventions (e.g. Macdonald, 2021). Provision of services outside formal structures might lead to social rights and protections being lost (Sedacca, 2022).

Domestic care platforms in coordinated and mature market economies in Europe have as yet escaped the scrutiny of researchers. While there are a variety of models formalising the provision of domestic care services in different European countries, platform workers have no access to the employment and social protections enjoyed by workers hired by traditional care providers. Whether this increases the scope for domestic care platforms to steer informal employment within such markets remains an empirical question. While traditional care service providers employ care workers on a regular basis, platforms tend to avoid employment costs by treating workers as self-employed (Berg et al., 2018), potentially enhancing risks for the workers involved.

Recent research, including the study we present here, shows that national governments have started to actively support the domestic care platforms (see the National Disability Insurance System NDIS in Australia, Macdonald, 2021). Thus, we intend to deepen our understanding of national policies by broadening explanations of platforms' strategies of dominance (Haidar and Keune, 2021). While research illustrating how domestic care platforms interact with established sectors is scarce, the few studies available raise concerns when comparing platforms to traditional firms providing care work. First, platforms supply workers directly to individual clients and often take payments from both parties. Second, as platforms are not service providers, they do not bear the costs and risks of service provision. For example, in Australia Macdonald (2021: 103) found that 'labour hire licensing regulation may not apply where firms "on-hire" workers to individuals or households, as the workers are not being hired to perform work in and as part of a business'. Employment protection applies only when the labour hire firm is covered by labour hire licensing regulation, which leaves care platforms outside this regulation as they do not supply care labour to service providers. Likewise, Ticona (2022) and Ticona and Mateescu's (2018) study of care platforms in the US illustrate how neoliberal policies and weak regulation have embraced the invisible infrastructure of insecure platform work.

Hence, there is a need to broaden our understanding of how national labour market regulations and government policies are promoting the transformation of relations within domestic care work and whether this in turn is undermining prospects for decent work by passing on costs to workers through an individualisation of risk. Our research in Belgium and France illustrates that platforms individualise risk by fostering informal employment, a feature to a large extent responsible for the production of unpaid labour.

Research design and methodology

We use a comparative case study design to explore the individualisation of risk in relation to unpaid labour in care platforms in Belgium and France. While both countries are mature and coordinated

market economies, they differ significantly in the organisation of domestic care and employment arrangements in this domain. The two platforms selected operate in a similar manner, a key prerequisite for analysing how comparable domestic care platforms interact with different national regulatory systems in the sector. Selection involved several stages. First, we conducted desk research to determine all platforms active in the domestic care sector. Second, we sampled two platforms (Yoopies and Top Help/Aide au Top) with similar operations in both countries, paying particular attention to matching functions and the systems used to rate and review workers. To deepen our understanding of platforms' operations, we then created client and worker accounts with a view to performing basic interactions (e.g. posting a job, replying to messages, running worker searches in different locations, etc.) on both platforms.

We used narrative interviews with workers as the main way to investigate their experiences in relation to the risk of unpaid labour when providing services through platforms. A total of 27 narrative interviews were conducted with domestic care workers active on Yoopies and Top Help in Belgium and France, as well as two semi-structured interviews with sectoral trade union experts (one in Belgium and one in France). Respondents were selected to ensure a sample as diverse as possible in terms of gender, age and jobs performed via the platform (Table in Appendix 1). We recruited respondents through the platforms and social media. We used our client accounts to contact potential respondents, whereby we fully disclosed our intention to conduct an interview (instead of offering a domestic care job), in compliance with our ethical guidelines. To recruit through social media, we joined Facebook groups run by domestic care workers, either posting on the group wall or directly contacting group members fitting our sampling criteria. Workers were financially reimbursed for time spent participating in an interview. Interview data were analysed through the software NVivo using thematic coding (Glaser and Strauss, 1967), with unpaid labour and work arrangements as the main themes, which we connected to the functioning of the platforms and the institutional contexts.

Systems of domestic care work in France and Belgium

Legislation was introduced in the mid-2000s in both France and Belgium to formalise and regulate their domestic care service sectors, a traditional hotbed of informal and undeclared work (Lutz and Palenga-Möllenbeck, 2010). Regulations in both countries were designed to incentivise users to declare the services purchased, namely through generously (state)-subsidised voucher schemes. Yet despite both countries using such schemes, regulations differ significantly, reflecting different policy goals (Farvaque, 2015; Sansoni, 2009).

In France, the 2006 introduction of vouchers under the CESU (*Chèque emploi service universel*) system was part of a larger reform of social services – the so called Plan Borloo – that aimed at generally liberalising the provision of domestic services (Devetter and Messaoudi, 2013). The French voucher system thus applies to all domestic care services (i.e., help for the elderly and persons with disabilities, private tutoring, babysitting, household tasks, etc.) and gives clients a large degree of choice and control over the service and service provider. From an employment perspective, the system establishes the 'presumption of employment' (*presumption de salariat*) between the client-employer and the provider-worker that is to be formalised (on the CESU website) once the client has selected a provider. Anyone can become a 'service provider' at any time, without professional or institutional (e.g. self-employment) requirements (except for childminders who need certification). Clients can select and recruit providers directly, without having to resort to a service agency. Once recruitment is successful and the employment contract is legally registered, the worker is automatically recognised as employee, and covered by the CESU sectoral collective agreement negotiated at national level setting minimum pay rates, fringe benefits, minimum health

and safety standards, and access to social protection. To incentivise formalisation, the CESU system offers a 50 per cent tax credit to clients/employers on the whole amount paid for domestic care services in the previous year (tax credits are paid out the following year after the annual tax declaration), as a form of compensation for the increased costs. The French government directly recommends platforms like Yoopies to clients on the official CESU website. Some scholars criticise the French domestic care employment model as inadequate, as it burdens workers with the costs related to searching for and accessing work, while depriving them of the job stability offered by a standard employment relationship (Devetter and Messaoudi, 2013).

In contrast to France, Belgium's voucher system only covers specific domestic services (i.e., cleaning, cooking, ironing and laundry services), while the provision of services more closely related to personal assistance remains within state social care structures. The system is intended to formalise the domestic work sector, making it a new outlet for employment growth and helping activate the unemployed and hard-to-employ workforce, while offering a source of affordable domestic services to middle-class households (Sansoni, 2009). The Belgian voucher system is organised around a 'triangular' scheme that connects domestic service agencies, clients and workers (Safuta and Camargo, 2019). While tax incentives in France are provided *ex post*, in Belgium the state subsidies are included in the discounted vouchers that clients buy from their regional authorities (the cost for clients is around €9 per hour of work). Clients use vouchers to purchase domestic services through state-accredited domestic service agencies, which then assign workers to perform tasks. The agency acts as an employer, mediating and organising the provision of services to clients and hiring workers as regular full- or part-time employees. Employment conditions in the sector are collectively bargained at national level and regulate pay, working time, access to social security (e.g. unemployment benefits), and health and safety. The national regulation also mitigates job-related risks by preventing workers being tasked with dangerous activities such as climbing up ladders and cleaning windows. Personal domestic care services (i.e., assistance to the elderly and persons with disabilities, and early-childhood education) are provided as in-kind services organised by regional and local authorities in partnership with public, not-for-profit and private providers (Farvaque, 2015). Care workers in this sector are employed by the service providers and therefore enjoy standard employment working conditions regulated by national collective bargaining. Lastly, neither babysitting services nor private tutoring are subject to any form of regulation in Belgium, meaning that service providers in these fields have no access to regular employment or social protection.

Platforms' operations

Yoopies and Top Help/Aide au Top (hereinafter: Top Help) are French-based platforms active in a number of countries worldwide, including France and Belgium. Both provide client households with access to domestic care services – such as cleaning, babysitting, private tutoring, personal assistance to the elderly and to persons with disabilities, while allowing workers to offer their services. Both supply the digital infrastructure for the parties to contact each other directly: workers create profiles and set rates in selected job categories (e.g. babysitting or private tutoring), while clients can either select workers directly from a list of workers and then contact them through the platform's chat, or post job offers to which workers apply.

An algorithm lists workers' profiles in line with the selection criteria entered by a client (e.g. service type, location, etc.). Also displayed are ratings and reviews left by previous clients, profile information, workers' availability, and their activity on the platform. Top Help workers can improve their ranking through 'badges' gained by earning 'points' through performing certain activities such as completing profiles or advertising the platform on social media.

Whereas registration is free of charge, both platforms offer paying (i.e., premium) accounts to both clients and workers. For workers, premium accounts lead to better positions in search result lists, as well as providing direct access to client contact details, thereby increasing the chances of finding work. Similarly, premium accounts allow clients to access a worker's contact details (e.g. their phone numbers), facilitating direct communication.

After 'matching' workers and clients, both platforms leave the practical work arrangements to be agreed between the parties, i.e., not doing anything to enforce the terms and conditions set forth in the collective agreement. In France, Yoopies offers paying clients the option of administrative support to formally declare the contracted jobs via the platform under the CESU system. Clients can optionally pay through the platform's transaction system which automatically calculates the worker's pay in accordance with CESU minimum rates and social contributions. However, they can also opt to deal with work arrangements and payment on their own. This service cannot be used in Belgium where domestic care work is managed through agencies and companies acting as third-party employers.

Findings

Economic costs in domestic care platform work: access to work

For Belgian platform workers, costs are engendered from the moment they start looking for jobs. This is due to Yoopies and Top Help framing the 'matching' by inviting clients to 'hire' workers on an individual basis *as if* they were self-employed, in disrespect of the Belgian sectoral regulation. For workers, this entails losing the advantages associated with standard employment, as they are made individually responsible for bearing new economic costs (which are hard to recover through their rates on platforms and therefore go unpaid) by spending time undertaking tasks associated with accessing work. A first type of increased costs relates to finding work. In regular employment in Belgium, workers are guaranteed stable time-planning – and related income – established by their employers. However, platform care workers looking for jobs must invest significant effort in creating their profiles, promoting themselves by writing detailed descriptions of their educational background and work experience, creating a sense of trustworthiness by adding pictures, and constantly updating their availability, to make themselves visible and attractive:

> *'It takes some time to fill out your profile, make a small ad. I tried to include that I'm studying medicine [. . .] that I have specific experiences in babysitting and with the elderly. You introduce yourself as completely as possible.'* (BEGIGMF08)

Many Belgian workers showed awareness of the additional effort required to access work through platforms as '*you need to really do a lot on the website, for your profile, to really sell yourself*' (BEGIGCM07) compared to through the standard employment system. However, producing an attractive profile is not enough to find clients. Workers also spend substantial time looking for jobs and sending applications to clients. In our sample, workers consistently showed frustration when applications went unanswered, meaning that *'work is done for nothing'* (BEGIGMF27). This is due to clients being able to tap into a large pool of workers, without being obliged to let candidates know that the selection is over:

> *'I send a message to three to four people. But it's a little annoying they don't say "No, I don't need help" or "I already have someone".'* (BEGIGMF27)

When workers are pre-selected by potential clients, they are usually invited for job interviews. This entails time and commuting costs, without any guarantee of getting the job. Compared to regular off-platform domestic care work in Belgium, where workers are assigned to clients by their employment agency, platform workers are made to bear the additional costs associated with job interviews. Workers often reported that '*Interviews can last a long time: one hour, one hour and a half [. . .] I had one that lasted two hours!'* (BEGIGCM04).

French platform workers have the same to report: *'I sent at least 20–30 applications. I never got a reply, not even a refusal [. . .] I bear the costs of all this myself'* (FRGIGCM24). However, the matching systems used by Yoopies and Top Help comply with the French CESU regulation making job searches an unpaid responsibility of workers. Both Belgian and French platform workers face relatively high costs when accessing paid work due to the highly competitive environment: '*there are so many people [workers] registered on this site'* (BEGIGMF11) while '*there is little variation in the number of jobs posted'* (FRGIGCM29). Workers are encouraged to gain an advantage over their peers by obtaining good ratings and reviews to increase their visibility vis-à-vis clients: *'I asked her [client] to write me a review [. . .] and she did that right away. I really liked that. [. . .] Now I am 83 per cent visible and pretty high up on the list'* (BEGIGMF30). However, the rating system can have negative effects on workers as it encourages them to put up with unrealistic requests from clients expecting more than stipulated in the task description, for fear of getting a negative rating. Workers can find themselves in situations where:

> *'There are clients that ask you – in four hours! – to clean the tiles, go grocery shopping, clean the whole apartment, pick up whatever is on their floor, the McDonald's bags and the cat's dry pee. We're talking apartments that haven't been cleaned in eight months.'* (BEGIGCM04)

Some workers purchase premium accounts to gain an advantage among their peers, as this gives them direct access to client phone numbers. Moreover, premium accounts '*work on the algorithm to make my profile jump up among the first hits in the lists that clients see'* (FRGIGCM11), thereby granting a visibility 'premium'. The charge for a premium account is between €7 and €10 per month – an investment which is hard to recover when workers find jobs '*that pay €18 in total on the other side of the city'* (BEGIGCM04).

Another way in which platforms pass on risks to workers is by not protecting them against frequent last-minute cancellations that involve a loss of (planned) income essential for workers to offset the cost of the tasks performed to find clients through the platform. The failure to recuperate these costs can generate frustration:

> *'This person was absolutely not fair: she cancelled the appointments three times. Once I was ten minutes away from the meeting place, and she calls me and says: "Sorry, I'm not here, can we postpone this until tomorrow?"'* (FRGIGCM29)

Economic costs in domestic care platform work: performing work

Findings reveal that the majority of work relationships matched through both platforms remain informal. In Belgium, this is because platforms' 'matching' operations require clients to directly hire workers, in disrespect of the sectoral regulation. A Belgian elderly-care assistant active on Yoopies explained that the financially most beneficial option was to agree to under-the-table arrangements, as registering as self-employed would imply tax charges so high that workers lose their price competitiveness:

> *'I chose to work through Yoopies because it's sort of under-the-table work. So I don't have to pay, say, €7000–€8000 in contributions and taxes every year.'* (BEGIGMF11)

In France, the CESU system allows clients to formalise the employment relationship *after* selecting the candidate. However, both platforms refrain from requiring the parties to sign CESU employment contracts and supervising compliance with regulatory schemes, thereby *de facto* letting clients determine work arrangements. Findings from France illustrate that these work arrangements are often informal, in particular when clients need *'small jobs, just for one evening or for a weekend'* and clients *'generally pay cash'* (FRGIGCM11). Thus, the casual and on-demand nature of a large share of the work requested on platforms discourages clients from registering workers under the CESU system. Registration entails not only a lot of paperwork, but also higher direct prices due to the social security contributions. One French interviewee gave a vivid account of this: a new client at first paid her through the (optional) Yoopies online transaction system which automatically charges clients the total amount including the deductible employer taxes; however, after the transaction, the client asked: '*but next time, can we do cash? Because Yoopies makes me pay €70'* instead of the *'€40 we had agreed on'* (FRGIGCM29).

One of the effects of non-compliance with employment regulations is wage dumping (and potentially unpaid work), as statutory minimum wages are not applicable. The informal work relationship gives clients greater bargaining power, letting *'clients set the price themselves [. . .] it's them who set and we accept'* (BEGIGCM07). In the highly competitive environment on care platforms, workers generally have to accept what clients offer. Consequently, hourly rates may be lower than the statutory minimum wage (around €10–€11 gross in both France and Belgium) with some clients paying *'not more than €5 per hour to take care of their child'* (FRGIGCM34). Workers acknowledge that some clients use platforms expressly to circumvent the high costs associated with the formal sector and pay rates below the statutory minimum:

> *'People have crazy requests, but well, hire a "normal" cleaning lady if you have such necessity. Don't go on Yoopies. Because they want to pay less. But at the same time, they expect the same level of professionalism and high-level service.'* (FRGIGCM29)

Despite low pay, workers often put up with clients' unrealistic demands to at least gain some (albeit limited) income and avoid negative ratings and reviews on the platform.

Commuting time and costs are further costs borne by workers in informal relationships, unless clients offer to cover transportation costs (in our sample only one worker reported such an occurrence). While both the French and Belgium regulations foresee reimbursement for commuting time and costs (e.g. '*When I worked under the Pajemploi system I earned more than if I had worked under-the-table because my commuting costs were paid'* (FRGIGCM33)), in the case of informal platform work these costs are not recovered by workers despite being necessary to perform paid work. The time and effort involved in commuting is magnified when jobs are casual and short (i.e., one to two hours), which is common on platforms. Respondents reported several cases when the time spent commuting was out-of-balance with gig remuneration:

> *'You have to take public transport, and that's not always profitable when you have to commute an hour and a half for barely two hours of work.'* (FRGIGCM29)

Importantly, the informal nature of most jobs posted on platforms means that workers are not entitled to the employment rights and social protection enjoyed by regular employees. These include bonuses, parental and sickness leave, work-related accidents insurance, unemployment benefits, and old-age pension. For instance, when platform workers operate informally, in-work

safety measures stipulated in national legislation are not applicable, as reported by one Belgian respondent:

> *'When I go to people's places I get on ladders, I take my risks. With the voucher system, this is forbidden.'* (BEGIGCM04)

Workers are thus exposed to higher degrees of risk (of accidents), without being entitled to accident insurance or sickness leave. They are individually responsible for the civil and medical costs directly related to accidents and cannot receive incapacity benefits, potentially generating further costs for them.

Social costs involved in domestic care platform work

The non-recoverable costs that platforms pass on to workers relate not only to the economic but also to the relational and – more specifically – 'socio-emotional' dimension of work. We describe 'socio-emotional' as including both the psychological and cognitive activities. We found that platform workers develop empathic relations and attachment to their clients, while being required to manage their emotions, such as for instance:

> *'To always remain patient, respect the child's well-being, not to raise your voice, but to know how to be firm without raising your voice [. . .] be as communicative as possible with the child.'* (FRGIGCM11)

Indeed, emotional labouring aimed at being patient, docile and proactive acquires even greater importance for platform workers as client dissatisfaction can easily lead to a negative review affecting access to future employment on the platform. As in other service-oriented professions, platform workers must:

> *'Always try to be as polite as possible, even when people have been vile or not-so-friendly.'* (FRGIGCM11)

At the same time, we saw platforms limiting workers' knowledge about clients and the jobs while assigning them responsibility to perform knowledge work, finding out as much as they can about clients. While platforms require workers to create full profiles, clients have much lower entry barriers and are allowed to post jobs with scant information about themselves and the services requested. The platform thus passes on to its workers the burden of 'figuring out' a client's expectations. We found these efforts have the greatest relevance when platform workers are confronted with 'scams' – usually 'sexual-based scams'. Some respondents reported unsettling proposals from clients:

> *'He called me with a masked number, [. . .] he told me he owned a private clinic for cosmetic surgery in Los Angeles and he had plenty of money, and that he would like to have some nice company when he's in France [. . .] and he asked me to go do some chores at his place and he would pay me €30, €50 per hour.'* (FRGIGCM28)

Most workers seemed highly aware that 'on the (platforms) there are people who pretend to be families looking for (a cleaning lady) – but actually they are looking for something else' (BEGIGCM03). A significant number of the workers interviewed told stories of scams and/or misuse of the platform services. They reported requests to perform cleaning jobs late at night or in unusual dress such as 'working in a bikini' (BEGIGCM03). Some even reported sexual harassment while performing work. Workers reported deep uneasiness and fear, for example when clients insistently requested 'body massages' (BEGIGCM03), or even forced a worker to stay on in

the apartment (BEGIGCM05). Whereas national legislation provides assistance and support to harassed and abused workers, platform workers are individually responsible for coping with harassment or abusive clients and the associated sense of insecurity. They are often afraid of reporting the offences, due to the informal and thus unprotected work arrangements. The 'fuzziness' of client profiles and job descriptions generates feelings of physical insecurity and uneasiness when workers meet new clients, since contacts have been limited to on-platform messaging. A considerable number of respondents reported habitually notifying family members or friends about the client they were about to work for, a precautionary measure taken in the absence of any protection provided by platforms:

> *'I always write down in a little notebook the clients I've worked for, name, address, phone number, etc., and before I leave I drop it off at my mum's house. If anything happens, there's the information.'* (FRGIGMF08)

Discussion and conclusion

This article sets out to critically explore how domestic care platforms impact work arrangements within two mature market economies in Europe: Belgium and France. Both countries feature different – yet, relatively encompassing – welfare and employment systems established by governments and social partners with the aim of formalising employment in domestic care services. Despite the diversity of the country-based regulations, we indicate that platform domestic care workers incur unpaid labour. We explain unpaid labour by referring to the 'individualisation of risk' (see Macdonald, 2021) incurred by care workers when providing services through platforms, broadening the 'individualised risk' perspective by identifying and explaining its antecedents, i.e., unpaid labour understood as the cost of such risk. Unpaid labour stems in particular from platforms putting pressure on existing labour markets and welfare structures for formalised domestic care by imposing their (digital) employment models and rules which follow platforms' strategies of 'market dominance' (Haidar and Keune, 2021). Empirical evidence from Belgium and France shows similar outcomes: i.e., platform-mediated employment remains generally unrecognised, undocumented and therefore informal and open to unpaid labour. However, unpaid labour occurs in different ways in Belgium and France, reflecting the different national legislation governing the care and domestic sector co-opted by platforms (Stark and Pais, 2021). In France where the statutory system hinges on flexible employment with relatively low levels of protection, platforms find a fertile terrain to operate in a regime of semi-compliance where they are able to avoid liability for monitoring and enforcing statutory employment regulations (i.e., 'entrance by regulatory avoidance'). The domination strategies of platforms in France involve allegedly operating within the law, yet acting as a 'Trojan horse' as they fail to enforce the legal prescriptions, resulting in informal work. Conversely, in Belgium, where sectoral regulations set relatively higher levels of employment protection (often under standard employment), platforms have no other option but to operate by 'disrupting' existing labour institutions (i.e., 'entrance by disruption'). Above all, the disruptiveness of platforms in Belgium is visible in the direct employment relationship they promote, which the Belgian system does not foresee, leaving platform workers without any option to formalise their work. Policy-makers and unions should be aware of the potentially negative effects that the entrance of digital platforms can have on working conditions in domestic care work and on existing policies aiming to formalise employment in this sector.

In both countries, platform strategies hinging on the deployment of digital technologies make jobs more casual and without social protection, and pay unpredictable and unreported. In concrete terms, this involves passing on to workers the economic (including monetary assets such as working time) and social costs (including for example the need to constantly display patience and kindness, the need to 'figure out' clients' expectations to avoid scams, manage harassment, etc.) in the

Table 1. Social and economic costs for workers in regular employment and platform work.

Type of employment Social and economic costs for workers	Regular employment in Belgium (voucher system, domiciliary care assistance)	Regular employment in France (non-platform CESU and Pajemploi)	Employment via platforms
Profile creation and self-promotion to access work	No	Yes	Yes
Job search and application filing	No	Yes*	Yes*
Participation in job interviews	No	Yes*	Yes*
Additional non-remunerated tasks (e.g. to maintain high ratings)	No	No	Yes
Working below the minimum wage	No	No	Yes
Loss of pay due to last-minute cancellation	No	No	Yes
Commuting costs and time	No	No	Yes
Lack of access to social rights and protection	No	No	Yes
Lack of accident insurance coverage	No	No	Yes
Collecting information on clients and figuring out potential scams	No	No	Yes

*Although regular employees in France incur the costs of job search, application filing, and participation in job interviews, these costs are amplified in the case of employment via platforms due to the casual nature of platform-based care work.

form of unpaid labour for performing care tasks throughout the whole work process. Whereas informal employment represents a similar outcome in both Belgium and France, the individualisation of risk (i.e., unpaid labour) fostered by platforms impinges differently on workers, reflecting differing national legislation governing domestic care services. Under the voucher system in Belgium, domestic care services (excluding babysitting and private tutoring which remain outside the scope of the regulation) are carried out by employees on standard employment contacts. Therefore, workers accessing paid work in the traditional labour market in Belgium do not need to engage, for example, in digital activities associated with searching and applying for jobs, because they are matched with clients by the agencies that employ them. Conversely, the French regulation allows domestic care providers to be formally employed by clients directly under a 'private employment' relationship. This means that, even in regular employment, French workers are forced to bear the costs of searching and applying for jobs. Evidence points to platforms increasing the amount of unpaid labour burdening workers when searching for jobs on platforms due to the highly competitive platform environment that compels workers to perform labour-intensive self-branding activities involving both economic and social costs. On a similar note, platforms' deployment of reputational mechanisms puts pressure on workers, making them feel obliged to perform additional (unpaid) tasks to deliver their best performance (and thereby rule out the risk of a negative review). This contrasts strongly with the Belgian regulated system, where – as indicated – domestic care workers are not used to undertaking 'voluntary tasks' as their job description is regulated by the sectoral collective agreement. Conversely in France, unpaid labour in domestic care potentially remains a structural feature. Indeed, domestic care work there is highly flexible and 'incomplete' from the point of view of traditional employment protections despite efforts to formalise the sector (Devetter and Messaoudi, 2013). In this context, public policies should first and foremost support and promote good employment rather than bad jobs in the formal domestic care sector, as a precondition for avoiding creating a fertile terrain for platforms to flourish and steer jobs towards informal employment (Table 1).

Our study shows how platforms in Belgium and France boost informal employment in contexts of formalised domestic care employment by burdening workers with a significant amount of economic and social costs resulting from the individual risk in the form of unpaid labour. Thus, we contribute to the debate on the 'visibility' and 'invisibility' of care work on digital labour platforms (see e.g. Mateescu and Ticona, 2022; Weber et al., 2021) by contending that, whereas workers may appear more visible thanks to their presence on digital platforms and media (for instance, through rich personal profiles), their work remains invisible because it is stripped of the guarantees and protections – that limit the performance of unpaid labour – embedded in formal employment.

Our study has implications for policy-makers and trade unions focusing on domestic care platform work. First, the lack of enforcement of existing regulations on platforms is a major driver of individualised risk. We argue that it is this non-enforcement that has enabled platforms to carve out a share of the market through their domination strategies in France and Belgium. This suggests the need to expand and apply existing regulations in care services to platforms in order to improve the working conditions of workers. It also requires extending existing national regulations on the care services sector to occupations which are to date unregulated, i.e., babysitting and tutoring. This calls for an active role of the state and trade unions as regulators through legislation and collective agreements. Although collective agreements establish minimum working conditions in domestic care, these standards remain relatively and comparatively lower in the feminised care sectors than those in male-dominated sectors. Moreover, feminised care sectors remain comparatively less organised by trade unions than male-dominated industrial sectors. Organising strategies by trade unions are key to boosting workers' bargaining power and improving working conditions when negotiating with employers, in this case the platforms. Second, our study urges a deepening of our understanding of national policies, as well as a broadened analysis of platforms' domination strategies, looking at the extent to which and how platforms steer employment by a process of 'individualised risks' and assessing the implications thereof for workers.

Funding

The research on which this article is based received funding from the European Research Council (ERC Advanced Grant) under the European Union's Horizon 2020 Research and Innovation Programme ResPecTMe Project – 'Resolving Precariousness: Advancing the Theory and Measurement of Precariousness across the paid/unpaid work continuum' [grant agreement n° 833577] and the FWO – Flemish Research Council [Grant/Award Number: G073919N] (PI: Valeria Pulignano).

References

Anderson B (2007) A very private business: Exploring the demand for migrant domestic workers. *European Journal of Women's Studies* 14(3): 247–264.

Berg J, Furrer M, Harmon E et al. (2018) *Digital Labour Platforms and the Future of Work. Towards Decent Work in the Online World*. Geneva, Switzerland: ILO, pp. 1–136.

Brennan D, Cass B, Himmelweit S et al. (2012) The marketisation of care: Rationales and consequences in Nordic and liberal care regimes. *Journal of European Social Policy* 22(4): 377–391.

Christensen K and Manthorpe J (2016) Personalised risk: New risk encounters facing migrant care workers. *Health, Risk and Society* 18(3–4): 137–152.

Daniels AK (1987) Invisible work. *Social Problems* 34(5): 403–415.

D'Cruz P and Noronha E (2016) Positives outweighing negatives: The experiences of Indian crowdsourced workers. *Work Organisation, Labour and Globalisation* 10(1): 44–63.

Devetter FX and Messaoudi D (2013) Les aides à domicile entre flexibilité et incomplétude du rapport salarial: conséquences sur le temps de travail et les conditions d'emploi. *La Revue de l'IRES* 78(3): 51–76.

Ehrenreich B (2010) *Nickel and Dimed. On (Not) Getting By in America*. New York, NY: Henry Holt and Company.

Farvaque N (2015) *Thematic Review on Personal and Household Services*. Brussels: European Commission.

Fine M (2004) Renewing the social vision of care. *Australian Journal of Social Issues* 39(3): 217–232.

Franke M and Pulignano V (2021) Connecting at the edge: Cycles of commodification and labour control within food delivery platform work in Belgium. *New Technology, Work and Employment*. Epub ahead of print 13 October 2021. DOI: 10.1111/ntwe.12218.

Frenken K, Waes A, Pelzer P et al. (2020) Safeguarding public interests in the platform economy. *Policy & Internet* 12(3): 400–425.

Friederici N, Reischauer G and Lehdonvirta V (2022) *The business of European platforms*. Report Project Platform Alternatives. Berlin, Germany; Oxford: Alexander von Humboldt Institute for Internet and Society and the Oxford Internet Institute.

Glaser B and Strauss A (1967) *The Discovery of Grounded Theory: Strategies for Qualitative Research*. New York, NY: Routledge.

Haidar J and Keune M (2021) Introduction: Work and labour relations in global platform capitalism. In: Haidar J and Keune M (eds) *Work and Labour Relations in Global Platform Capitalism*. Cheltenham: Edward Elgar, pp. 1–27.

Hardill I and Baines S (2011) *Enterprising Care?: Unpaid Voluntary Action in the 21st Century*. Bristol: The Policy press.

Hochschild AR (1983) *The Managed Heart. Commercialization of Human Feeling*. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press.

International Labour Organization (ILO) (2020) Promoting employment and decent work in a changing landscape. In: *International labour conference, 109th Session 2020*. Geneva, Switzerland: ILO.

Lawson V (2007) Geographies of care and responsibility. *Annals of the Association of American Geographers* 97(1): 1–11.

Lutz H and Palenga-Möllenbeck E (2010) Care work migration in Germany: Semi-compliance and complicity. *Social Policy and Society* 9(3): 419–430.

Macdonald F (2021) *Individualising Risk. Paid Care Work in the New Gig Economy*. Singapore: Palgrave Macmillan.

Mateescu A and Ticona J (2022) Visibility regimes in online platforms for domestic work. In: Das Acevedo D (ed.) *Beyond the Algorithm*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, pp. 57–81.

Meagher G, Lundström T, Sallnäs M et al. (2016) Big business in a thin market: Understanding the privatization of residential care for children and youth in Sweden. *Social Policy & Administration* 50(7): 805–823.

Pulignano V and Franke M (2022) Control and consent regime dynamics within labour platforms. *Work in the Global Economy* 2(2): 149–175.

Pulignano V and Marà C (2021) *Working for nothing in the platform economy : Forms and institutional contexts of unpaid labour*. Solidar. Available at: https://www.solidar.org/system/downloads/attachments/000/001/410/original/Thematic_publication_Working_for_Nothing.pdf?1638980551 (accessed 12 December 2021).

Pulignano V, Piasna A, Domecka M et al. (2022) Does it pay to work? Unpaid labour in the platform economy. ETUI Policy Brief 2021.15. Brussels: ETUI.

Rani U, Dhir RK, Furrer M et al. (2021) *World employment and social outlook: Trends 2020. The role of digital labour platforms in transforming the world of work*. ILO Flagship Report. Geneva, Switzerland: ILO, pp. 1–283.

Sadowski J (2020) The internet of landlords: Digital platforms and new mechanisms of rentier capitalism. *Antipode* 52(2): 562–580.

Safuta A and Camargo B (2019) The more things change, the more they stay the same? The impact of formalising policies on personalisation in paid domestic work – the case of the service voucher in Belgium. *Comparative Migration Studies* 7: 14. Epub 24 April. DOI: 10.1186/s40878-018-0111-5. Available at: https://doi.org/10.1186/s40878-018-0111-5 (accessed 15 January 2022).

Sansoni AM (2009) Limits and potential of the use of vouchers for personal services. An evaluation of titres-services in Belgium and the CESU in France. ETUI Working Paper 2009.06. Brussels: ETUI.

Sedacca N (2022) Domestic work and the gig economy. In: De Stefano V, Durri I, Stylogiannis C et al. (eds) *A Research Agenda for the Gig Economy and Society*. Cheltenham: Edward Elgar, pp. 149–166.
Sevenhuijsen S (2003) The place of care. The relevance of the feminist ethic for social policy. *Feminist Theory* 4(2): 179–197.
Stark D and Pais I (2021) Algorithmic management in the platform economy. *Ekonomicheskaya Sotsiologiya* 22(3): 71–103.
Strüver A and Bauriedl S (2022) *Platformization of Urban Life: Towards a Technocapitalist Transformation of European Cities*. Graz: Transcript.
Ticona J (2022) *Left to Our Own Devices: Coping with Insecure Work in a Digital Age*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
Ticona J and Mateescu A (2018) Trusted strangers: Carework platforms' cultural entrepreneurship in the on-demand economy. *New Media and Society* 20(11): 4384–4404.
Weber CE, Okraku M, Mair J et al. (2021) Steering the transition from informal to formal service provision: Labor platforms in emerging-market countries. *Socio-Economic Review* 19(4): 1315–1344.

Appendix

Appendix 1. Overview of interviews with workers.

Platform	Country	Respondent code	Services offered on platform	Age	Gender
Yoopies	Belgium	BEGIGMF08	Personal assistance to the elderly/Babysitting	27	F
		BEGIGMF11	Personal assistance to the elderly	49	F
		BEGIGCM03	Cleaning, household tasks/Babysitting	27	F
		BEGIGCM04	Cleaning, domestic tasks/Personal assistant to the elderly and persons with disabilities/Babysitting	57	F
		BEGIGCM06	Cleaning/Babysitting	29	M
		BEGIGCM07	Babysitting	34	F
	France	FRGIGCM07	Pet-sitting/Cleaning	20	F
		FRGIGCM08	Cleaning, domestic tasks/Babysitting	22	F
		FRGIGCM24	Private tutoring/Babysitting	24	F
		FRGIGCM29	Private tutoring/Cleaning/Personal support to the elderly (no care assistance)	24	F
		FRGIGCM30	Private tutoring/Cleaning	27	F
		FRGIGCM31	Private tutoring	27	M
		FRGIGCM32	Pet-sitting/Babysitting	28	F
Top Help	Belgium	BEGIGMF27	Babysitting	50	F
		BEGIGMF30	Private tutoring/Babysitting	66	F
		BEGIGMF42	Private tutoring/Babysitting	24	F
		BEGIGMF43	Babysitting	24	F
		BEGIGCM11	Private tutoring/Babysitting	33	F
		BEGIGMF32	Babysitting	62	F
	France	FRGIGCM10	Cleaning, domestic tasks/Babysitting	42	M
		FRGIGCM11	Babysitting, pet-sitting, private tutoring	23	F
		FRGIGCM12	Cleaning, domestic tasks/Babysitting	32	F
		FRGIGCM20	Cleaning, domestic tasks	53	F
		FRGIGCM33	Babysitting	23	F
		FRGIGCM34	Private tutoring/Babysitting	23	F
		FRGIGCM35	Babysitting	50	F
		FRGIGCM37	Cleaning, domestic tasks/Babysitting	23	F